

York & the Minster - Kids

UK Family Tour

York: Walk on Top of a City's Armor

York is a city you can walk around ON TOP of — it still has its medieval walls, over three kilometers of them, the longest town walls in England, and walking them is free. But the story starts even earlier: Roman soldiers founded this city in the year 71 and called it Eboracum. It became so important that Roman emperors ruled the whole empire from here. Two emperors even died in York, and in the year 306, right where the Minster now stands, soldiers lifted a young man onto their shields and proclaimed him emperor: Constantine the Great — the emperor who went on to make Christianity legal across the Roman world and to found Constantinople. One of history's most important people got his job in York. Look for his statue lounging outside the Minster. As you walk the walls, you'll pass through fortified gates called "bars" — which is confusing, because in York, a bar is a gate and a gate is a street. Streets here are called "gates" — Stonegate, Petergate, Coppergate — from the Viking word "gata," meaning street. So in York: gates are streets, bars are gates, and the pubs are... also bars. Locals enjoy watching visitors work this out.

The Legion That Vanished

When the Romans built York, they didn't build a town first. They built an army base. A legionary fortress was the home of a whole legion, around five thousand highly trained soldiers, and the men who raised York's first walls and streets in the year seventy-one belonged to the Ninth Legion. Imagine the noise of it: thousands of soldiers drilling, blacksmiths hammering, carts rolling in through the gates, and, believe it or not, a giant heated bath, because Roman soldiers loved a good soak after a hard day. You can still stand right over a piece of that bathhouse today, underneath a pub in the middle of York that is actually called the Roman Bath. Now here comes the mystery, and it's a real one. The Ninth Legion was famous and tough. They were here, in York, building in solid stone. The very last certain trace of them anywhere in the world is a slab they carved to celebrate finishing a great gateway, around the year one hundred and eight. You can go and see that exact stone in the Yorkshire Museum, just a short walk away. And then, nothing. The Ninth Legion simply drops out of history. No battle report, no farewell, no record of where five thousand men went. For hundreds of years people have asked the same question you're probably asking right now: what happened to them? One famous story says they marched north into the wild lands beyond Scotland to fight fierce tribes, and were wiped out, every last one, and never came back. That's the tale in a well-known adventure book called *The Eagle of the Ninth*. But other experts think the legion was quietly shipped off to a far corner of the empire, thousands of miles away, and destroyed in some battle there instead. The honest answer is that nobody knows for sure. A whole army, thousands of soldiers, and history lost them. What we do know is that a new legion, the Sixth, marched into York to take their place, and stayed for hundreds of years. So as you walk these streets, remember you're treading the same ground as a legion that vanished, leaving behind their walls, their bathhouse, and one carved stone that seems to say: we were here. And then a question with no answer.

The Wooden Castle and the Saddest Night

Look for the grassy hill in the middle of York with a stone tower crouched on top, shaped a little like a four-leaf clover. That's Clifford's Tower, and its hill has a long and dramatic story. The hill itself is your first clue, because it isn't natural. When the Normans conquered England, their leader William marched north to control this rebellious city, and around the year ten sixty-eight his men piled up this enormous mound of earth by hand and built a wooden castle on top to keep watch over York. Wooden castles, though, have one big weakness. They burn. And the saddest part of this hill's story is about fire. In the year eleven ninety, something terrible happened here. A small community of Jewish families lived in York, under the special protection of the king. But an angry mob turned on them, partly because some of the attackers owed them money and wanted their debts to simply disappear. The families fled up this very hill and locked themselves inside the wooden tower for safety. Trapped, surrounded, with no way out, around one hundred and fifty people died on the night before an important holy day, and the wooden tower burned to the ground. It's not a happy story, but it's an important one, and York remembers it. There's a stone plaque at the foot of the mound so that the people who died here are never forgotten. The tower you see now came later. A king named Henry the Third rebuilt it in stone, in that unusual clover shape, so it could never burn so easily again. Except, well, it sort of did. In the year sixteen eighty-four a great explosion and fire gutted the inside, which is why the tower today is really a mighty stone shell with no roof, open to the sky. Climb up the steps if you can, walk around the top of the walls, and you'll get one of the best views in the whole city, right across the rooftops to the towers of the Minster. One small hill, and standing on it you've touched the Normans, a king, a tragedy, an explosion, and the finest photo spot in York.

The Shambles: The Wonkiest Street in Britain

Find the Shambles — a narrow, crooked street where the old buildings lean so far toward each other that neighbors in the top floors could reach across and shake hands. It's often called the best-preserved medieval street in Europe, and it looks so magical that many people believe it inspired Diagon Alley in the Harry Potter films — the film-makers never confirmed it, but the street is now full of wizard shops that are very happy for you to believe it. Here's the un-magical truth about why it looks this way: the Shambles was the street of the butchers. The word "shambles" originally meant the benches where meat was displayed — you can still see wide wooden shelf-sills under some windows, which were the meat counters. The buildings lean inward on purpose: the overhanging upper floors kept the sun off the meat hanging below. There were about twenty-five butcher shops here, and everything you'd rather not think about ran down the channel in the middle of the street. That's why "a shambles" came to mean a total mess — the word you use when your room is a disaster comes from this exact street. Today it smells considerably better: mostly fudge.

The Ghost Soldiers in the Cellar

Here's one of the most famous ghost stories in all of England, and the strangest part is what came afterwards. Near the Minster stands an old house called the Treasurer's House. The story goes that back in nineteen fifty-three, a young man named Harry Martindale, just eighteen years old, was working alone down in the cellar, fixing pipes, standing near the top of a ladder. Suddenly he heard a sound: a single note, like a trumpet, blown over and over, growing louder. And then, out of the solid stone wall, a soldier stepped into the cellar. Behind him came a great tired carthorse, and then rows and rows of Roman soldiers, marching, looking exhausted and filthy, carrying round shields and spears. Harry was so terrified he tumbled off his ladder and pressed himself into a corner. But here's the eerie detail that makes people believe him. He could only see the soldiers from the knees up. Their feet were hidden, as if they were walking on a road lower than the cellar floor. Harry told this story for the rest of his life, always exactly the same way, and he never once accepted money to tell it. Now for the part that gives people goosebumps. Years later, archaeologists dug beneath that very house, and what did they find? A real Roman road, a proper stone highway, running right where Harry said the soldiers walked, at exactly the level of their hidden feet. Even stranger, the odd round shields Harry described, which experts first said were wrong for Roman soldiers, turned out to match soldiers who really were stationed in York much later in Roman times. How could a young plumber who knew almost nothing about Roman history describe all that correctly? Nobody can explain it. Maybe he saw ghosts. Maybe there's another answer we simply haven't thought of yet. But if you visit the Treasurer's House, remember that somewhere beneath your feet runs an ancient road, and once, so the story goes, a whole column of soldiers came marching down it, straight out of the wall. Listen for a trumpet.

The Boy from York Who Tried to Blow Up Parliament

Every year on the fifth of November, all across Britain, the sky fills with fireworks and people light huge bonfires. And it all began with a boy from York. His name was Guy Fawkes, and he was born right here in the year fifteen seventy, in a house on a street called Stonegate, just around the corner from the Minster. When he was only a few days old, he was carried into the little church that still stands right beside the great cathedral, called Saint Michael le Belfrey, and baptised there. You can walk past both spots today. As a boy, Guy went to school in York, and by all accounts he was clever and serious. But he grew up in dangerous times, when people could be punished for the way they prayed, and Guy came to believe the government was treating people like him cruelly. So he joined a daring and dangerous plot. In

the year sixteen hundred and five, he and a group of others hid dozens of barrels of gunpowder in a cellar right underneath the Houses of Parliament in London, planning to blow the whole building sky-high in one enormous explosion. But the plot was discovered at the very last minute. Guards crept down into the cellar in the dark, and there they found Guy Fawkes, standing guard over the barrels, ready to light the fuse. The plot failed completely. And that is why, every November, people light bonfires and set off fireworks, remembering the night the great explosion did not happen. Sometimes they even burn a straw figure called a guy, named after him. But here's a lovely York twist. It's said that Guy's very own old school in York, which is still open today, politely refuses to burn a guy on Bonfire Night, out of respect for a boy who once sat in its classrooms. So the most famous troublemaker in British history was a York schoolboy, and the whole country lights up the sky because of him. Not bad, or perhaps not good, for a lad from Stonegate.

York Minster: 250 Years of Building

York Minster is one of the biggest cathedrals in Europe — so big it took two hundred and fifty years to build, from 1220 to 1472. Think about that: the workers who started it knew they'd never see it finished. Neither would their kids. Or their grandkids. Stonemasons spent whole lifetimes carving, and a team of masons still works here today, in the same stoneyard, replacing worn stones with new hand-carved ones — the building has basically never stopped being built. Inside, look east for the Great East Window: the largest single medieval stained-glass window in the world, roughly the size of a tennis court, made by one master glazier, John Thornton, in just three years starting in 1405. It tells the story of the beginning and end of the world in over three hundred glass panels. Then find the Rose Window, and the Five Sisters — five tall grey-green windows made of thirteenth-century grisaille glass. Now the survival story: this glass has escaped fire after fire, including a huge one in 1984 when lightning struck the roof. Firefighters deliberately collapsed the burning roof to save the rest — and the Rose Window cracked into forty thousand pieces but held together, and was painstakingly repaired. Your ticket lets you return free for a year. The Minster plays the long game.

Monsters and a Clock for the Stars

The Minster is enormous, but the real fun is in the small things hiding high above your head, so keep looking up. First, hunt for the dragon. High on a wall in the long main hall of the cathedral juts a real wooden dragon's head, painted gold, sticking straight out into the air. Nobody today knows exactly why it's there, but the cleverest guess is that it was once a kind of crane, a lifting arm. People think a chain ran through a hole in the dragon's head, so the monks could raise and lower a heavy wooden lid that covered the font, the special stone basin where babies were baptised. A dragon that was really a machine. Next, go on a face hunt. Carved all around the stone, if you search, you'll find funny and fierce little faces. Some are grotesques, pulling silly or scary expressions to make you look twice. Others are green men, strange faces with leaves and vines sprouting right out of their mouths and noses, a mysterious carving found in old churches all over the country, and no one is completely sure what they mean. Then find something that looks like a clock but really isn't about telling the time at all. It's the astronomical clock, and instead of hours and minutes it shows the sun and the stars, drawn the way a pilot would see them looking out of a plane flying high over York. Why a pilot? Because this beautiful clock is a memorial. It was made to remember around eighteen thousand airmen, from this part of England, who flew away in the Second World War and never came home. Beneath it rests a book with their names written inside, and every single day someone gently turns a page. So in one great building you can find a dragon that was really a machine, faces with leaves growing out of them, and a clock that maps the sky for pilots who are gone. The Minster looks solemn and still, but it is actually full of secrets and surprises, hiding in plain sight, waiting for the family that bothers to look up and really see them.

The Night the Minster Caught Fire

On a stormy July night in nineteen eighty-four, disaster struck the Minster. A thunderstorm rolled over York in the small hours of the morning, lightning cracked down, and the roof of one huge arm of the cathedral, the south transept, burst into flames. The fire roared for hours in the darkness. The firefighters made an incredibly brave and painful decision: they deliberately pulled the burning roof down, collapsing it on purpose, because if they hadn't, the flames would have spread and might have destroyed far more of the ancient building. By morning the south transept was open to the sky, blackened and smoking. But here is where the story turns wonderful. When it was time to rebuild the ceiling high above, the builders needed new roof bosses. A boss is a carved knot of wood or stone, round like a badge, set at the exact

spot where the ribs of the ceiling cross each other, and the Minster's ceiling has dozens of them. Six of the old ones were gone. So the television programme Blue Peter set the children of Britain a challenge: design a new roof boss showing something important that happened in the twentieth century. Over thirty thousand children sent in drawings. Six winners were chosen, and their designs were carved and lifted up into the brand-new ceiling, where they still are today. So next time you're inside, tilt your head back and search the south transept roof. Among all the medieval saints and angels carved by people who lived six hundred years ago, you'll spot an astronaut walking on the Moon, because a child drew it. You'll find the raising of the Mary Rose, King Henry the Eighth's great warship, lifted from the bottom of the sea. There's a whale, and a deep-sea diver, all imagined by children not much older than you. Think about that. A cathedral that took two hundred and fifty years to build, that survived a terrible fire, now carries pictures dreamed up by ordinary kids, right up there among the treasures, meant to last for hundreds of years. Somewhere in England a grown-up today can point up at that Moon and say, I drew that when I was your age.

The Room with No Middle, and a Viking's Horn

Two last treasures before you go, and they're easy to miss. First, find the Chapter House. It's a beautiful room, and it has eight sides, like a giant stone drum, with a wide painted ceiling arching overhead. Now look for the pillar in the middle holding that heavy roof up. Go on, look. There isn't one. That's the trick, and it amazed people when it was built in the twelve eighties. Back then, a stone ceiling this wide would normally have needed a thick column planted right in the centre. But the medieval carpenters were so daring and so skilled that they built the whole roof out of wood, cleverly balanced so it holds itself up with nothing in the middle at all. The room is so proud of itself that there's an old saying carved inside, boasting that just as the rose is the best of all flowers, this is the best of all rooms. Second, go down into the Undercroft, the museum beneath the cathedral, and find the Horn of Ulf. It's a long curved horn, and it was carved from a real elephant's tusk almost a thousand years ago, far away in Italy, before it travelled all the way here to York. But it isn't just for decoration. A rich lord named Ulf, whose family were descended from Vikings, wanted to give his lands to the Minster. Today you'd sign papers. Back then, Ulf simply walked into the cathedral and handed over this magnificent horn instead, and everyone agreed the horn itself was the proof, as good as any signature. A drinking horn that stands for a whole estate of land. So there's your challenge for the Minster: find the room with no middle, and the elephant-tusk horn that once bought a piece of England. Do that, and you'll have seen two things that most visitors walk straight past without ever knowing they were there.